

Finding online assets responsibly

A short note I prepared for our students. Use good sources, respect copyright, and keep clear credit notes from the start.

Dear students, I prepared this guide so you have a reliable place to begin when you need textures, maps, sounds, or interface assets from the internet. Go to the original source, read the rights page, and save the credit details while you work.

Good habit

Start from the original source

Use creator websites, official institutions, and original publisher pages. Reposts are harder to trust.

Good habit

Read the rights page

Check the usage page before you download. If the terms are unclear, skip the asset and find a clearer source.

Good habit

Keep a credit note

Save the source, creator or institution, license, date, and edits in a small note beside the file.

How to search well

Use source words in your query, then open the page that explains rights.

moon texture nasa

mars global mosaic usgs

earth night map nasa

game ui assets CC0

CC0

Usually easy to use and share. Credit is optional, but still good practice.

CC BY

You may usually use and adapt it if you give clear attribution.

Public domain

Usually free to use, though the source may still ask for a simple credit line.

No clear license

Do not assume it is free. Choose a clearer source instead.

Trusted places to start

These are good starting points for textures, maps, and astronomical backgrounds. Click any card to open the source page.

Solar System Scope

Planet textures

Use it for. Ready made planet textures that are easy to bring into a real time scene.

Remember. The site states CC BY 4.0. Give credit and note any changes you make.

[Open source page](#)

NASA 3D Resources

Models and textures

Use it for. Official NASA textures, models, and visual material.

Remember. Read the NASA media guidance and do not use NASA branding in a way that suggests endorsement.

[Open source page](#)

Blue Marble

Earth daytime maps

Use it for. High quality Earth daytime textures and global Earth maps.

Remember. This is a strong source when you need a clean and familiar Earth surface for study or visual work.

[Open source page](#)

Earth at Night

Earth night lights

Use it for. Night side Earth textures and city light patterns.

Remember. Choose a resolution that fits your scene and keep the NASA source page in your notes.

[Open source page](#)

CGI Moon Kit

Moon color and height

Use it for. Moon color maps and elevation maps that hold up in closer views.

Remember. This is especially useful when you want surface detail, bump mapping, or displacement.

[Open source page](#)

Deep Star Maps 2020

Star backgrounds

Use it for. Star fields, sky domes, and space backgrounds.

Remember. These maps were designed for spherical mapping, which makes them very useful in 3D scenes.

[Open source page](#)



More useful sources

These pages are especially helpful when you want original science data, cropped map exports, audio, or interface assets.

USGS Astrogeology Search

Original science maps

Use it for. Planetary mosaics, geologic maps, and terrain data.

Remember. Product pages often list access and use constraints.

[Open source page](#)

Map a Planet 2

Crop and export tools

Use it for. Cropping or reprojecting a large USGS map.

Remember. Start from an Astropedia product and process only the image you need.

[Open source page](#)

NASA Sounds from Beyond

Space audio

Use it for. Authentic space related audio for demos and atmosphere.

Remember. Keep the NASA media guidance page open while you reuse the files.

[Open source page](#)

Kenney

UI and general assets

Use it for. Interface art, icons, buttons, and many general assets.

Remember. Kenney states that the asset page content is CC0.

[Open source page](#)



How to use these sources responsibly

Whenever you download an asset, do two things. Keep the source and rights details, and write a short credit note while the information is still easy to find.

Rights page

NASA media usage guidelines

Open this page whenever you plan to use NASA images, audio, or 3D assets.

[Open rights guide](#)

Rights page

USGS copyrights and credits

Open this page whenever you use USGS material or need official credit language.

[Open rights guide](#)

A simple workflow I want you to follow

Keep these details with every asset

- 1 Source page
- 2 Creator or institution
- 3 License or usage page
- 4 Date you accessed it
- 5 Changes you made

Simple credit examples

- 1 Solar System Scope texture, CC BY 4.0, source: Solar System Scope
- 2 Source: NASA Earth Observatory
- 3 Credit: U.S. Geological Survey
- 4 Kenney assets used under CC0

If a page is unclear about rights, do not guess. Choose another asset with a clearer source.